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Animal Experimentation Should Not Be Banned

The usage of animals in the research lab for experiments is called animal experimentation or animal testing. Many biomedical and psychological research labs use animals to test vaccines and theories/hypotheses. If the experiment shows positive results then the hypothesis or vaccine is used for the benefit of humans if not, then they are discarded and they try to develop a new one. The issue with it is that many people consider animal experimentation unethical. This is an ongoing controversy in the field of research.

Animals are living beings just like humans and it is cruel to inflict pain on them.

Millions of rats, cats, primates, dogs, and other animals are languishing in laboratories across the country. But just picture *one* animal—one monkey or one rabbit—writhing in pain after being purposely infected with a disease or dosed with chemicals, covered with gaping wounds or burns, starving and thirsty, aching with loneliness and longing to be free from invasive experiments, and overcome with terror any time a human walks past the cage that they're locked inside (Animals).

Monika Martyn, a nomadic minimalist and published author, says “Animal experimentation needs to end. It’s not a question of right or wrong. Animals have feelings and the right to live without cruelty inflicted on them for the sake of testing chemicals” (Martyn).

One of the reasons many people oppose animal testing is because of the belief that humans are not above animals, “It’s hard to imagine, as an intelligent species, we’re still discussing animal experimentation. There’s no doubt that animal testing is to the apparent benefit of people. However, that doesn’t make it right that over 100 million innocent animals suffer for our well-being” (Martyn).

Aysha Akhtar, a neurologist, preventive medicine specialist, and Fellow at the Oxford Centre for Animal Ethics says that,

The lack of sufficient congruence between animal models and human diseases is another significant obstacle to translational reliability. Human diseases are typically artificially induced in animals, but the enormous difficulty of reproducing anything approaching the complexity of human diseases in animal models limits their usefulness. Even if the design and conduct of an animal experiment are sound and standardized, the translation of its results to the clinic may fail because of disparities between the animal experimental model and the human condition (Akhtar).

People for the Ethical Treatment of Animals, PETA, is an organization that has been fighting for animal rights. It claims “Animal experiments prolong the suffering of humans waiting for effective cures because the results mislead experimenters and squander precious money, time, and other resources that could be spent on human-relevant research. Animal experiments are so worthless that up to half of them are never even published” (Animals).

There is no need to use animals when there are alternatives. “Finally, the testing of products on animals is completely unnecessary because viable alternatives are available. Many cosmetic companies, for example, have sought better ways to test their products without the use of animal subjects” (Save).

While I agree with some of the arguments against animal experiments, there are reasons for still continuing animal experimentation.

Animals are biologically very similar to humans. Mice share more than 98% DNA with us! Animals are susceptible to many of the same health problems as humans –cancer, diabetes, heart disease, etc. With a shorter life cycle than humans, animal models can be studied throughout their whole life span and across several generations, a critical element in understanding how a disease processes and how it interacts with a whole, living biological system (Why).

Some claims against using animal experimentation do not take into account the consequences of stopping the usage of animals for experiments.

Claims such as PETA's are half-truths that tell a lie. Yes, animal research takes time. And yes, findings in animals don't always correlate to use in people. And it is probably true that if we experimented directly on people from the beginning, treatments, and cures might be discovered more quickly. But doing so would be a human rights atrocity. In fact, experimenting with animals *before* testing on people is a crucial human rights protection required by the famous Nuremberg Code. More than that, if animal research were prohibited, scientific advances would be hopelessly stymied. Such a prohibition would stop *basic research*, and investigations into how organisms behave or function, which could never be conducted ethically in human beings (Smith).

Using animals for experiments resulted in the development of new medicine, “Virtually every major medical advance of the last century has depended upon research with

animals. Animals have served as surrogates in the investigation of human diseases and have yielded valuable data in the process of discovering new ways to treat, cure, or prevent them” (Importance).

Humans have and will continue to benefit from animal research.

Overall, animal research has and will continue to advance medicine in ways most people never even consider. In one way or another, either ourselves or through family members, we have all felt the benefits of animal research—every person who is cured of cancer, every person who lives a long life despite an HIV diagnosis, every person who keeps control of their diabetes, every person who has had surgery with the use of anesthetics (nearly all), every person who takes aspirin for headaches, every person who takes antibiotics for an infection (Keller).

I accept that using animals for experimentation causes at least a bit of suffering for them and doing it for the sake of humans is not something some people like but banning it completely might have adverse effects on the advancement of science and medicine. The advancement in these fields is necessary for the sake of nature and all living beings, not just for humans. One way around this controversy is to try to reduce the pain of animals as much as possible and another way is to look for alternatives.

There are alternatives that can be used such as using computers for the research by creating simulations.

This overall decline in animal use can be attributed to the advent of novel technologies such as improved cell-culture systems and microanalytic techniques; more sophisticated model systems; improved understanding of

signaling and metabolic pathways; and a host of other new methods that allow scientists to answer important questions about the functioning of healthy and diseased tissues without subjecting whole animals to harmful procedures (Rowan).

However, the usage of computers as an alternative has limitations. “Computer modeling plays an important part in the research process, however, its capacity to replace the use of animals is limited. Before one can program a computer model to reflect an aspect of our physiology, an understanding of the physiology being modeled is needed. This knowledge tends to come through research using animals. So, animals are needed before we even get to the computer” (Do).

Professor Stephen Hawking says “Computers can do amazing things. But even the most powerful computers can't replace animal experiments in medical research” (It Is).

The most they can do is reduce the use of animals and it is the same for other alternatives like MRI scanning that enables researchers to look into the brains of humans. “MRI scans may show us a problem in the brain, but animal research is likely needed to fix the problem. We cannot alter a human brain between MRI scans in an attempt to find a cure, so we must use animals first, to ensure the method's safety” (It Is).

The other way is to make sure the animals are treated humanely.

Any study that requests to use animals must go through a rigorous review via an institutional animal care and use committee (IACUC). Each institution has its own committee, which includes a variety of people including a lay person not involved in research. The committee ensures that the study is run properly and follows federal regulations laid out in the Animal Welfare Act and

the Public Health Service Policy on Humane Care and Use of Laboratory Animals (Keller).

Many researchers use anesthesia to make sure animals don't experience pain.

“According to the USDA, 93 percent of research animals do not experience pain related to experimental use either because the experiments have no painful procedures associated with them (58 percent) or because anesthesia and/or painkillers are used in the experimental protocol (35 percent)” (Experimenting).

Besides that, many biomedical research laboratories try to use the method named 3 “Rs” to make sure animals are not abused. “1. *Reduce* the number of animals used in studies to the minimum necessary. 2. *Replace* animals with other models whenever possible. 3. *Refine* procedures to make sure animals are treated as comfortably and humanely as possible” (Keller).

There is an alternative of using humans, who committed grave crimes and are given death penalty, as research subjects but human rights are violated in that case. Even if a person is a criminal, they need to give consent for that otherwise it is considered unethical. “Unethical human experimentation is human experimentation that violates the principles of medical ethics. Such practices have included denying patients the right to informed consent, using pseudoscientific frameworks such as race science, and torturing people under the guise of research” (Unethical).

May be in the future there can be other alternatives that can put an end to animal experimentation but for now the only way is to try to reduce the use of animals as much as possible and in case they use animals try to be as humane and kind to them as possible.

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